

Teaching a tool to someone who has never opened it

In-app guidance for Google Data Studio, built with the Whatfix Community edition: a twelve-step walkthrough, a one-page flow roadmap, and a Beacon and Self Help design.

The problem

Google Data Studio is free and capable. It is also a blank canvas, and a blank canvas is where new users stop.

So I did not document the product. I picked the one journey that makes the tool make sense — getting your own data onto a page and seeing it become a chart — and built guidance for that journey alone.

The principle: guide the task that is high in volume or expensive to get wrong. Leave the obvious alone.

Scope

Walkthrough

Twelve steps, from the Create button to a report that has been shared.

Top five flows

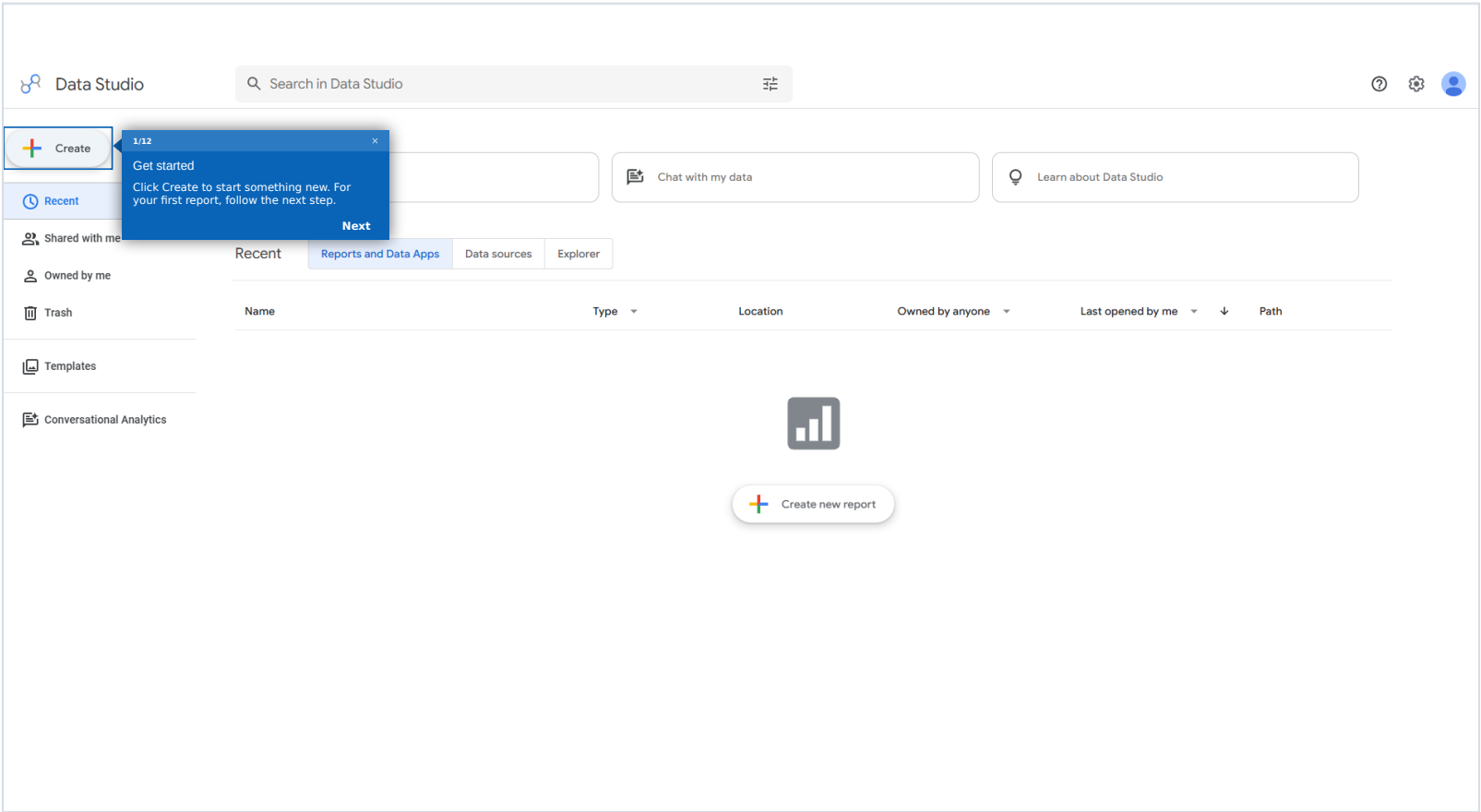
The next five journeys a beginner needs, ordered as a funnel.

Beacon and Self Help

One nudge towards a feature people miss, and an in-app help panel.

STEP 1

Click Create



WHY IT IS BUILT THIS WAY

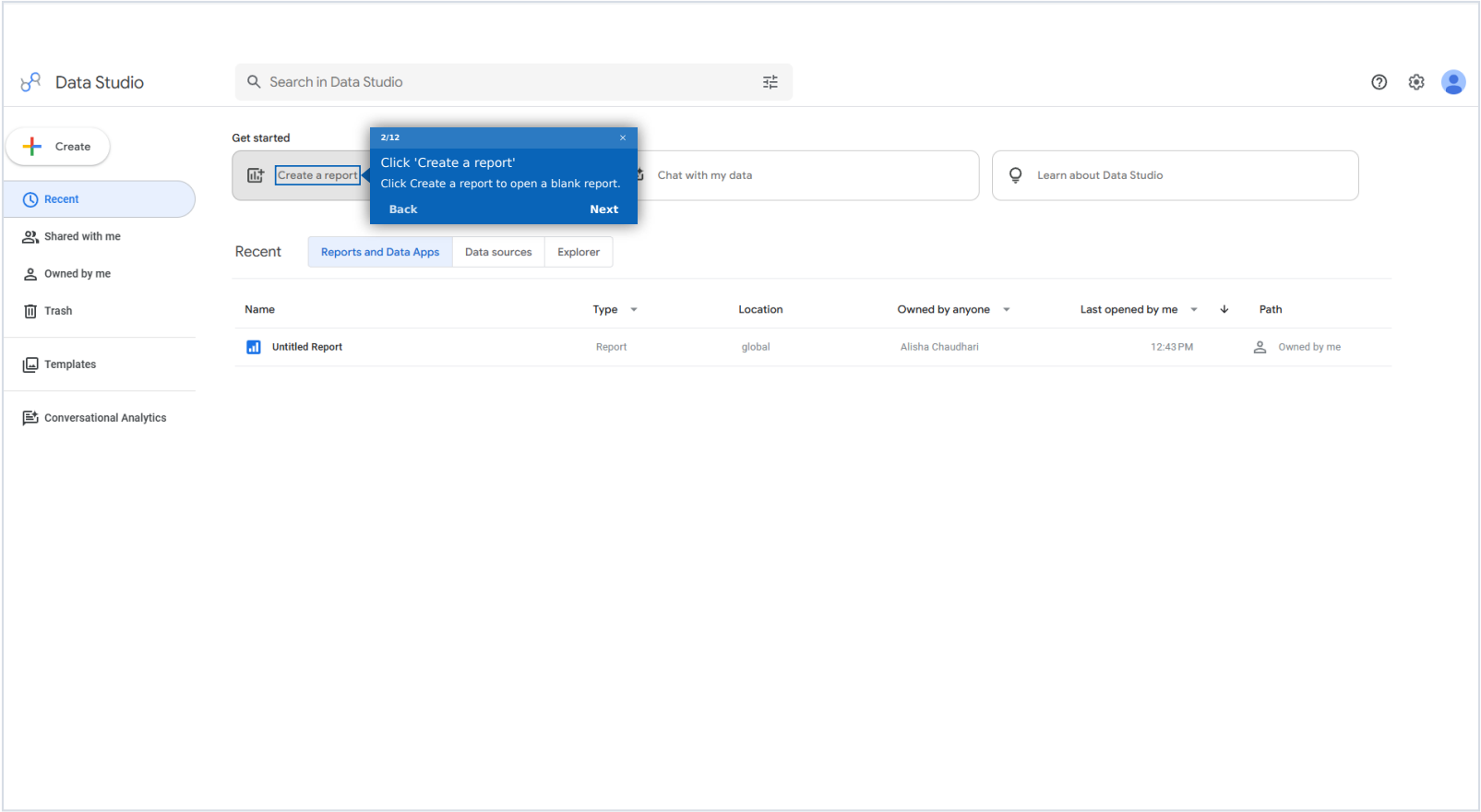
Start where every new user lands. Two clicks and they are inside the editor.

ON-SCREEN COPY

“Click Create to start something new. For your first report, follow the next step.”

STEP 2

Create a report



WHY IT IS BUILT THIS WAY

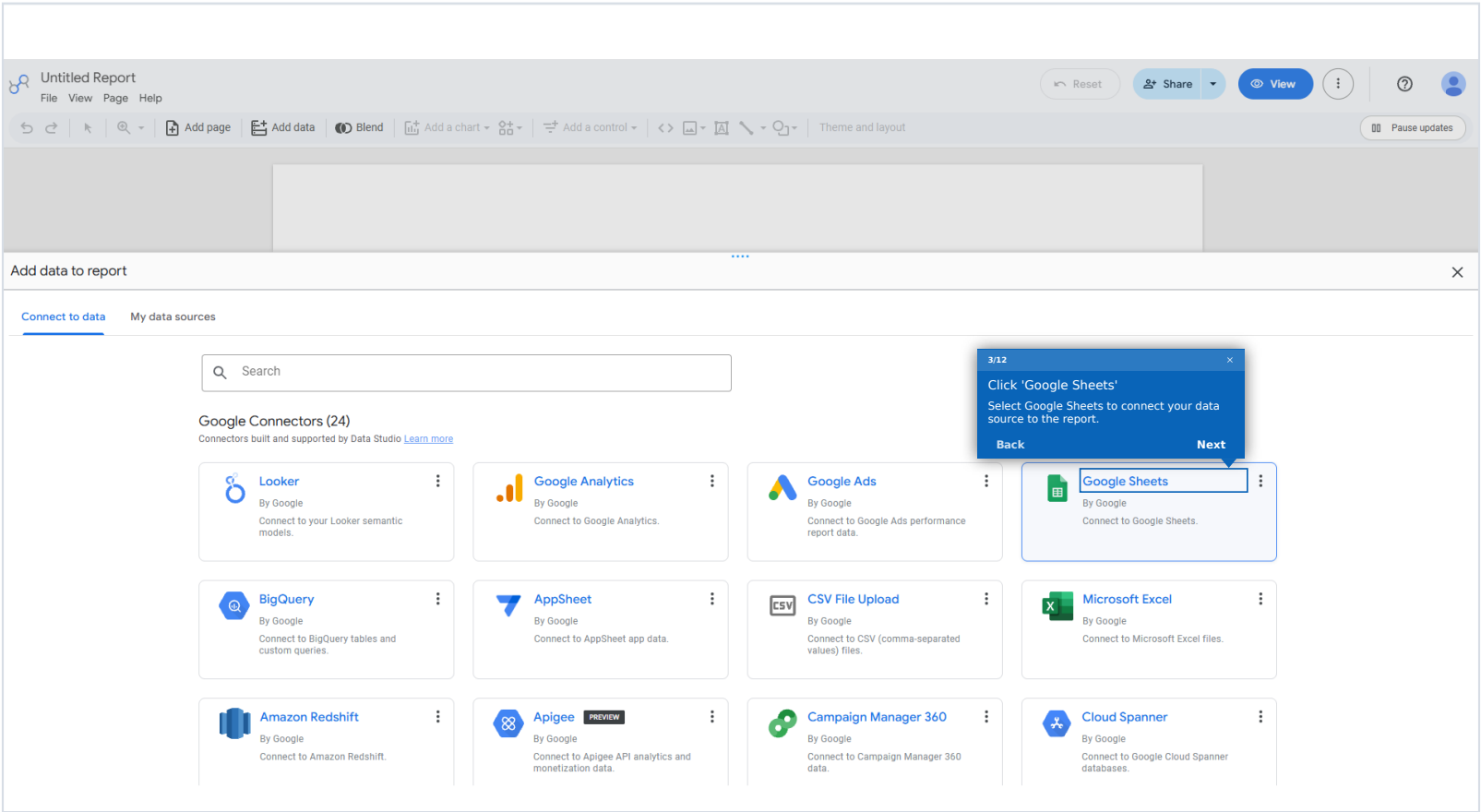
Straight to a blank report — no detour through templates or settings.

ON-SCREEN COPY

“Click Create a report to open a blank report.”

STEP 3

Choose Google Sheets



WHY IT IS BUILT THIS WAY

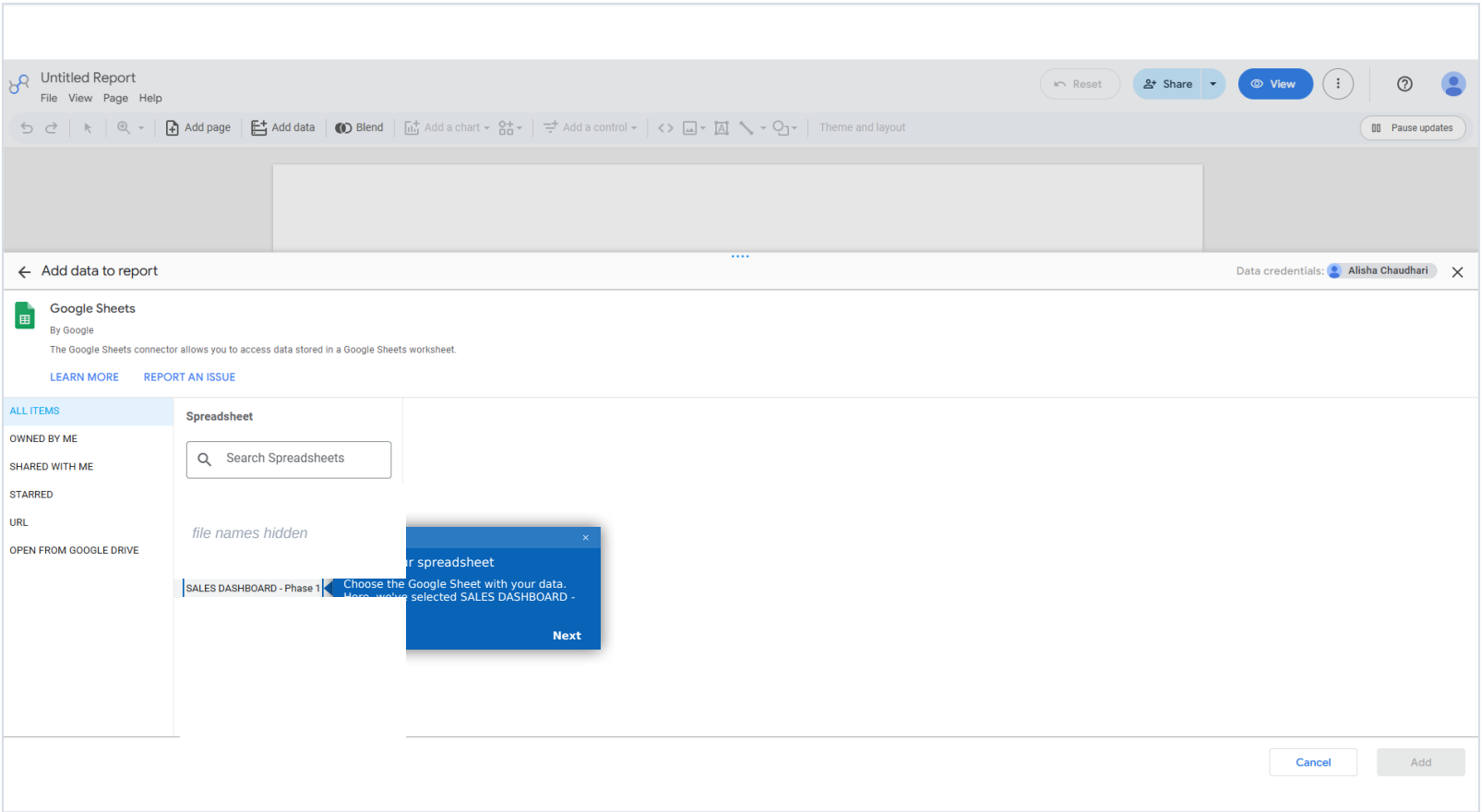
A beginner already has a Google account and a sheet. Other connectors add credentials, and credentials are where people stop.

ON-SCREEN COPY

“Select Google Sheets to connect your data source to the report.”

STEP 4

Select your spreadsheet



WHY IT IS BUILT THIS WAY

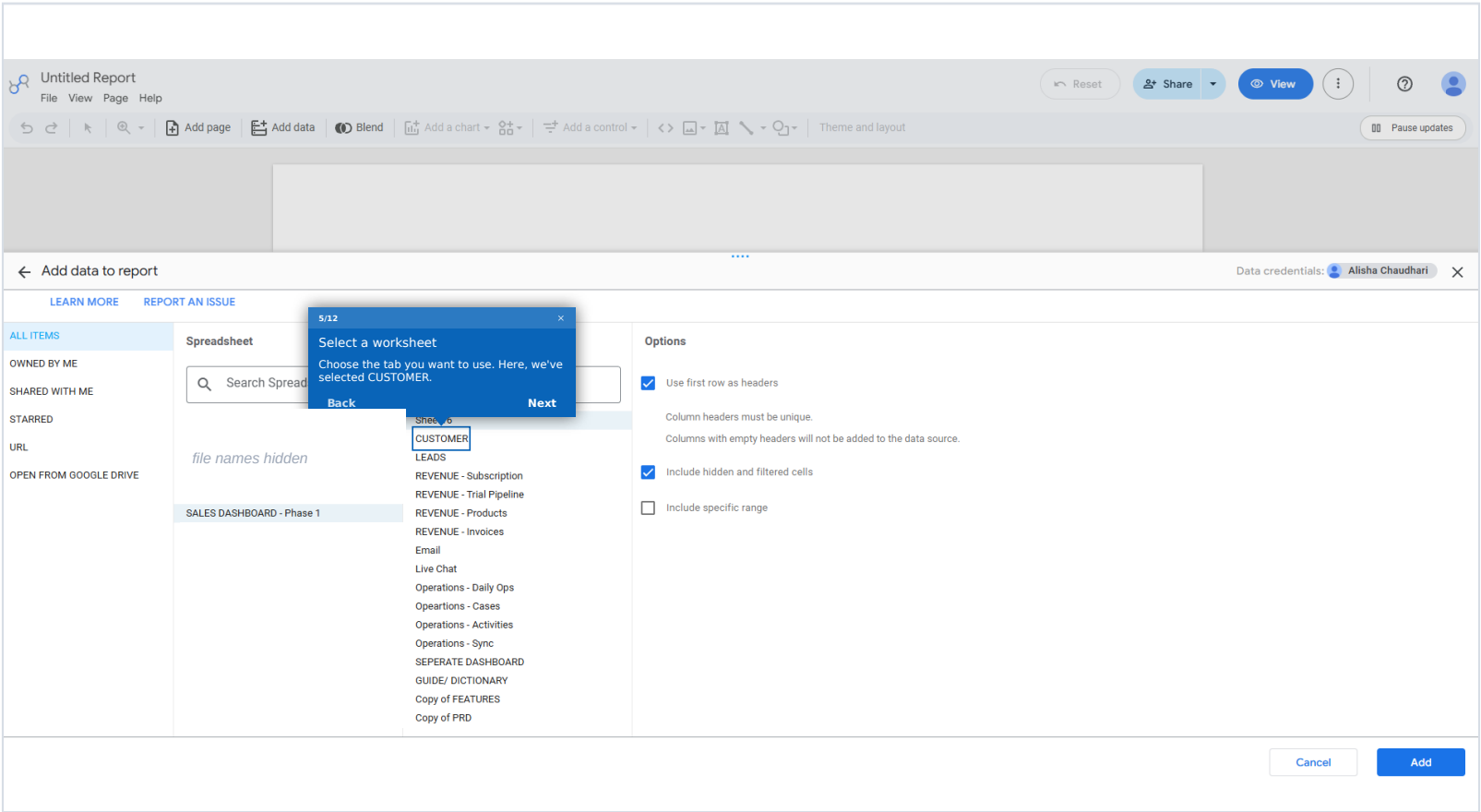
A real sheet rather than a demo file: guidance is trusted when it looks like the user’s own screen.

ON-SCREEN COPY

“Choose the Google Sheet with your data. Here, we’ve selected SALES DASHBOARD - Phase 1.”

STEP 5

Select a worksheet



WHY IT IS BUILT THIS WAY

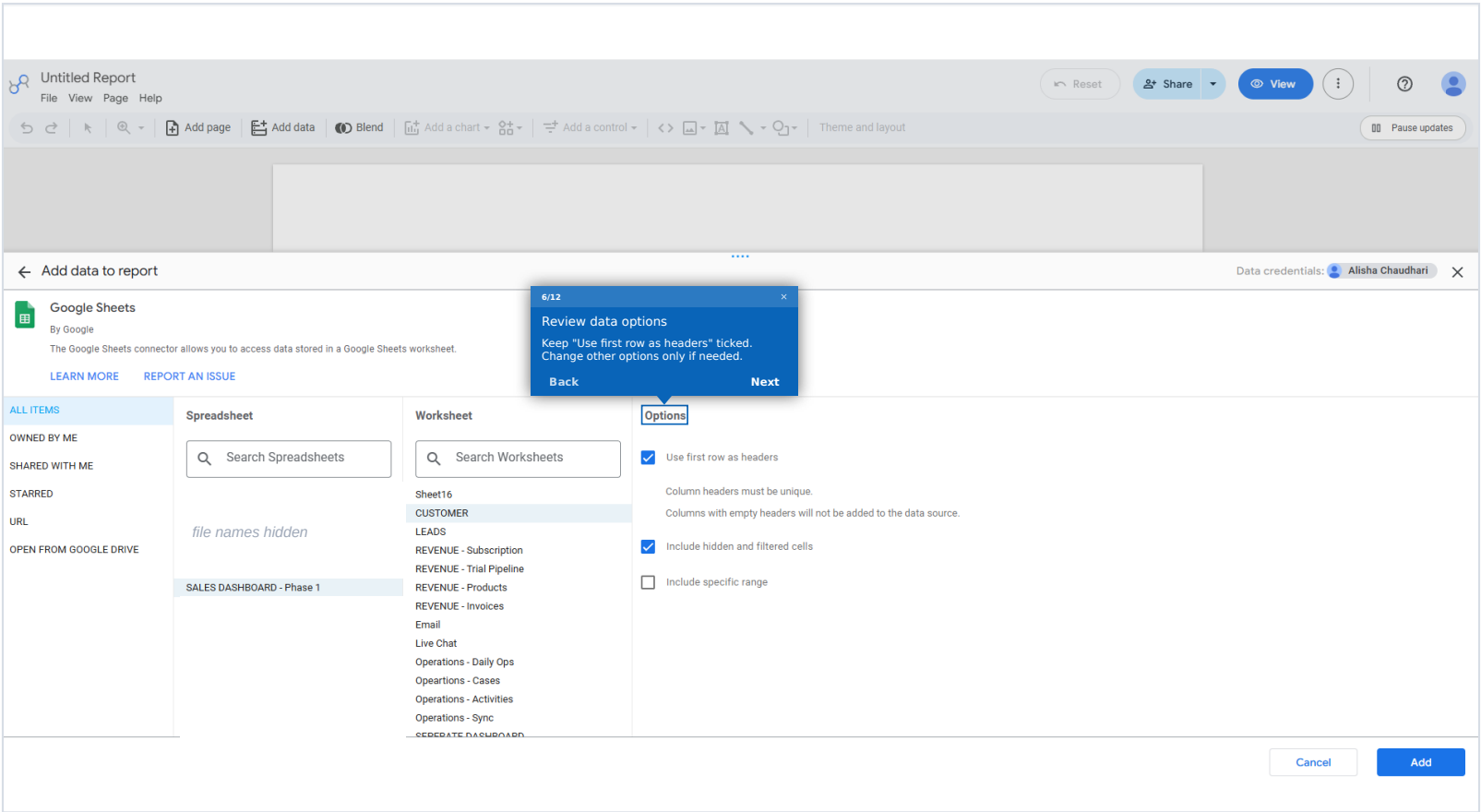
One tab, one data source. Naming the tab prevents the "which one was it?" question later.

ON-SCREEN COPY

“Choose the tab you want to use. Here, we’ve selected CUSTOMER.”

STEP 6

Review data options



WHY IT IS BUILT THIS WAY

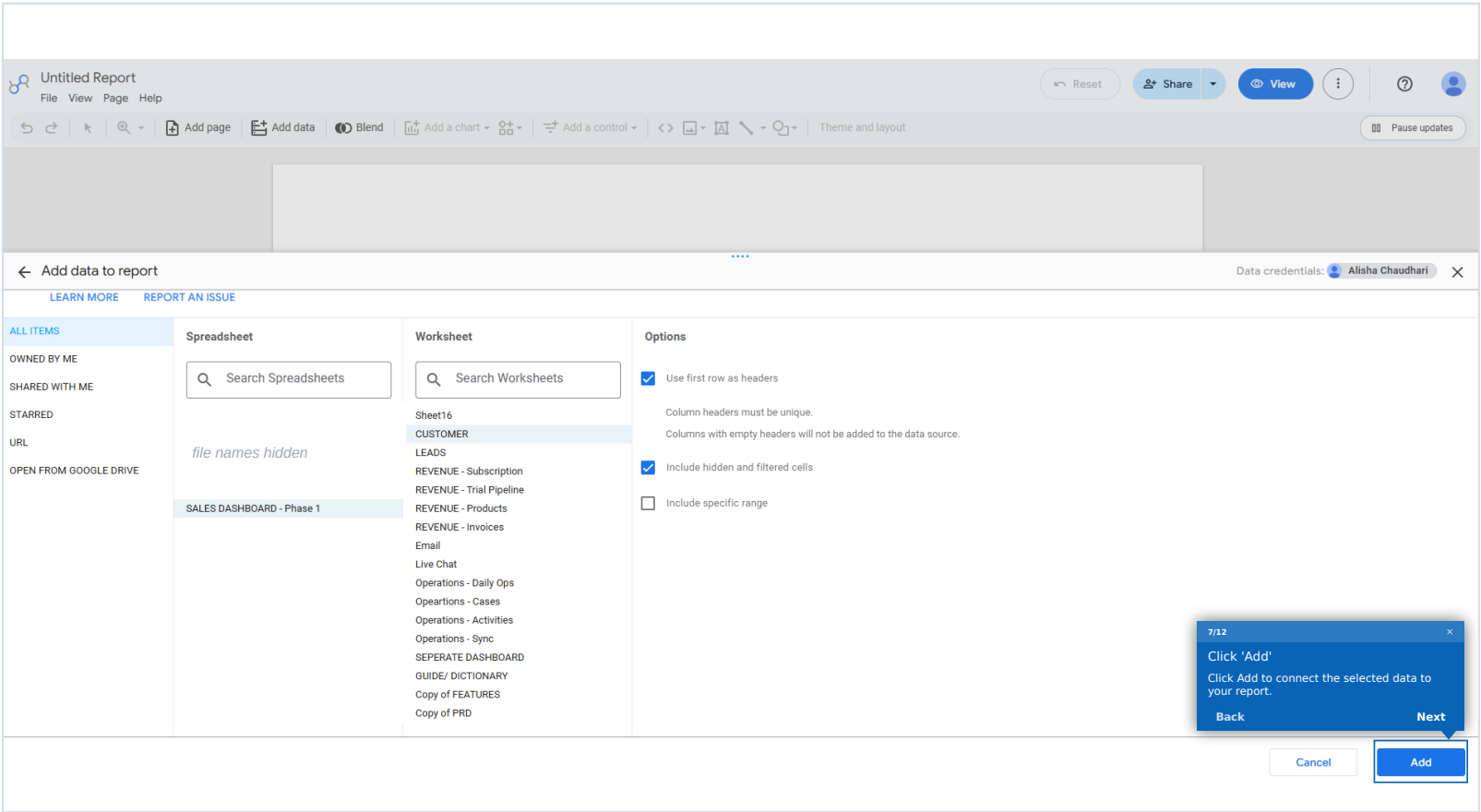
The silent failure. If "use first row as headers" is unticked, every field is named wrongly and the user concludes the tool is broken.

ON-SCREEN COPY

“Keep "Use first row as headers" ticked. Change other options only if needed.”

STEP 7

Click Add



WHY IT IS BUILT THIS WAY

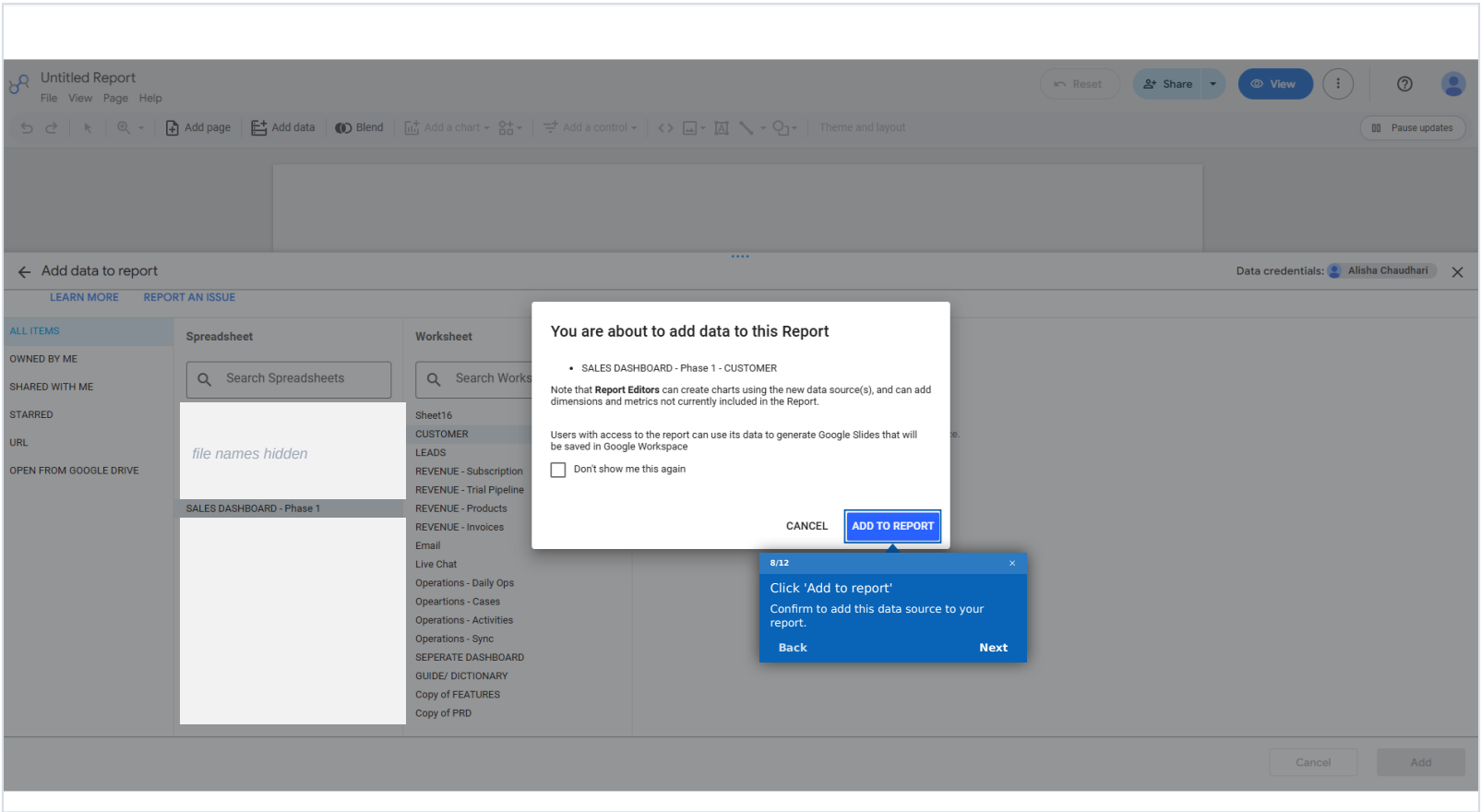
Two confirmations in a row is where people hesitate, so each one is given its own step.

ON-SCREEN COPY

“Click Add to connect the selected data to your report.”

STEP 8

Add to report



WHY IT IS BUILT THIS WAY

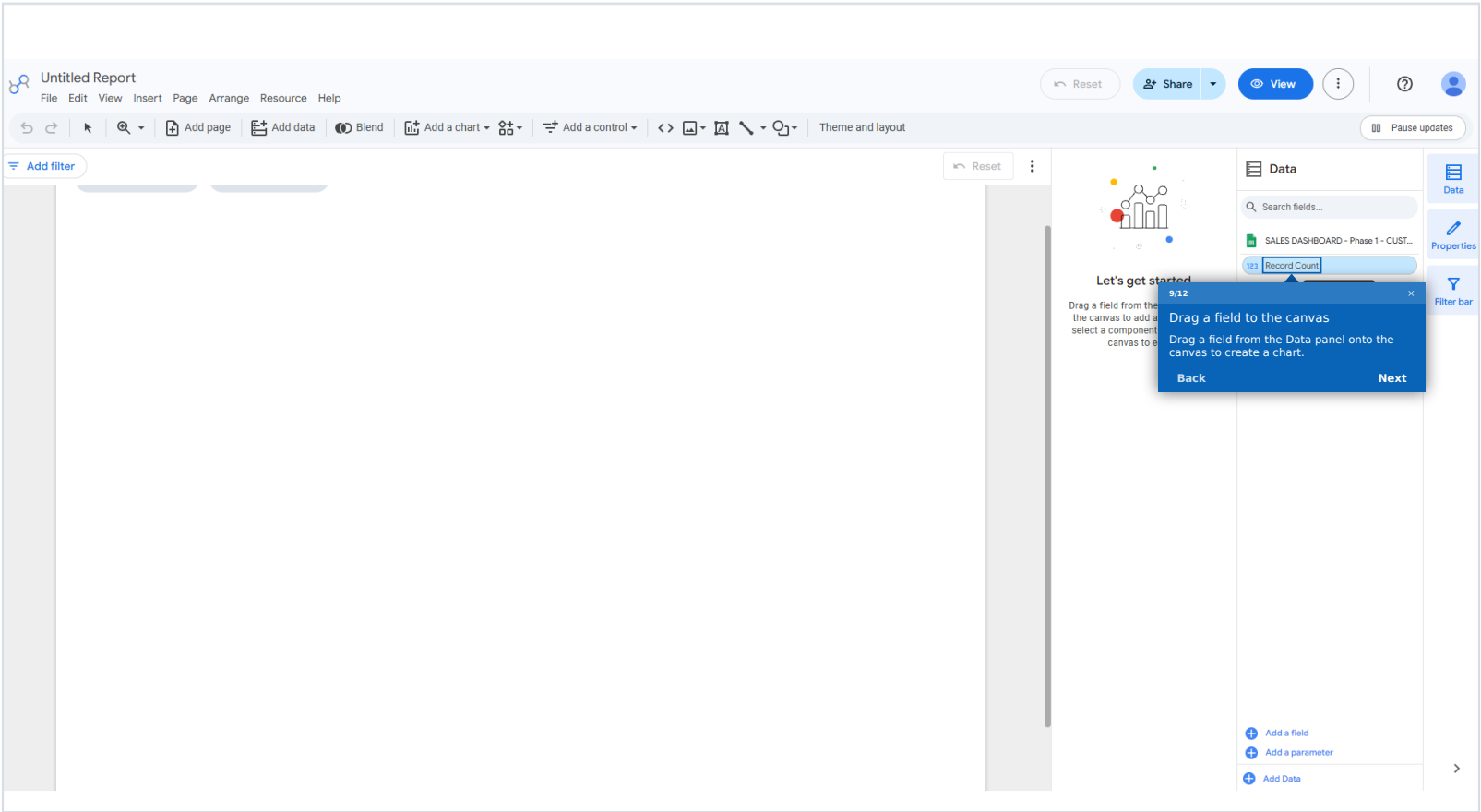
Confirm, and the data source is attached to the report.

ON-SCREEN COPY

“Confirm to add this data source to your report.”

STEP 9

Drag a field to the canvas



WHY IT IS BUILT THIS WAY

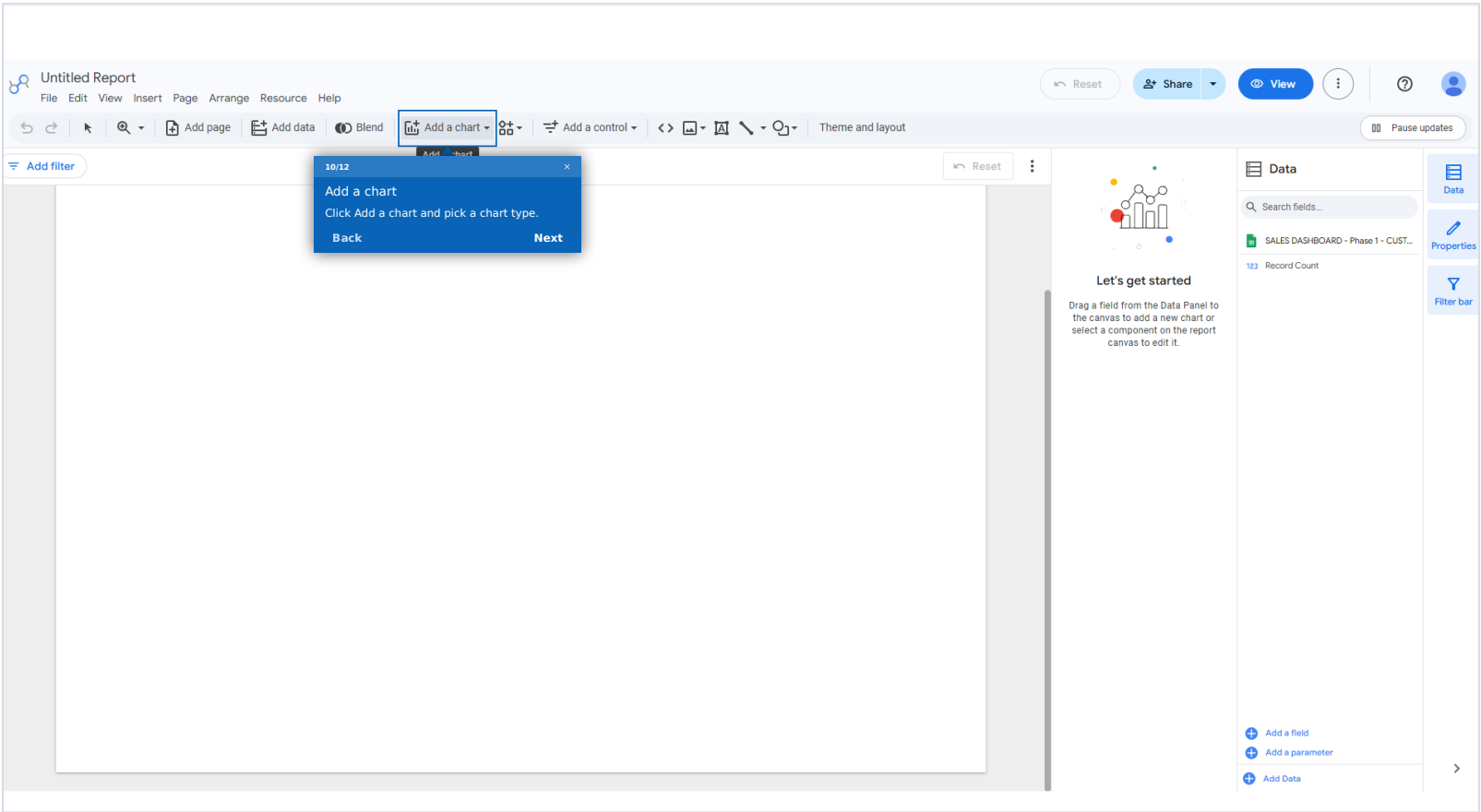
The first time the user makes something appear. This is the turning point of the session.

ON-SCREEN COPY

“Drag a field from the Data panel onto the canvas to create a chart.”

STEP 10

Add a chart



WHY IT IS BUILT THIS WAY

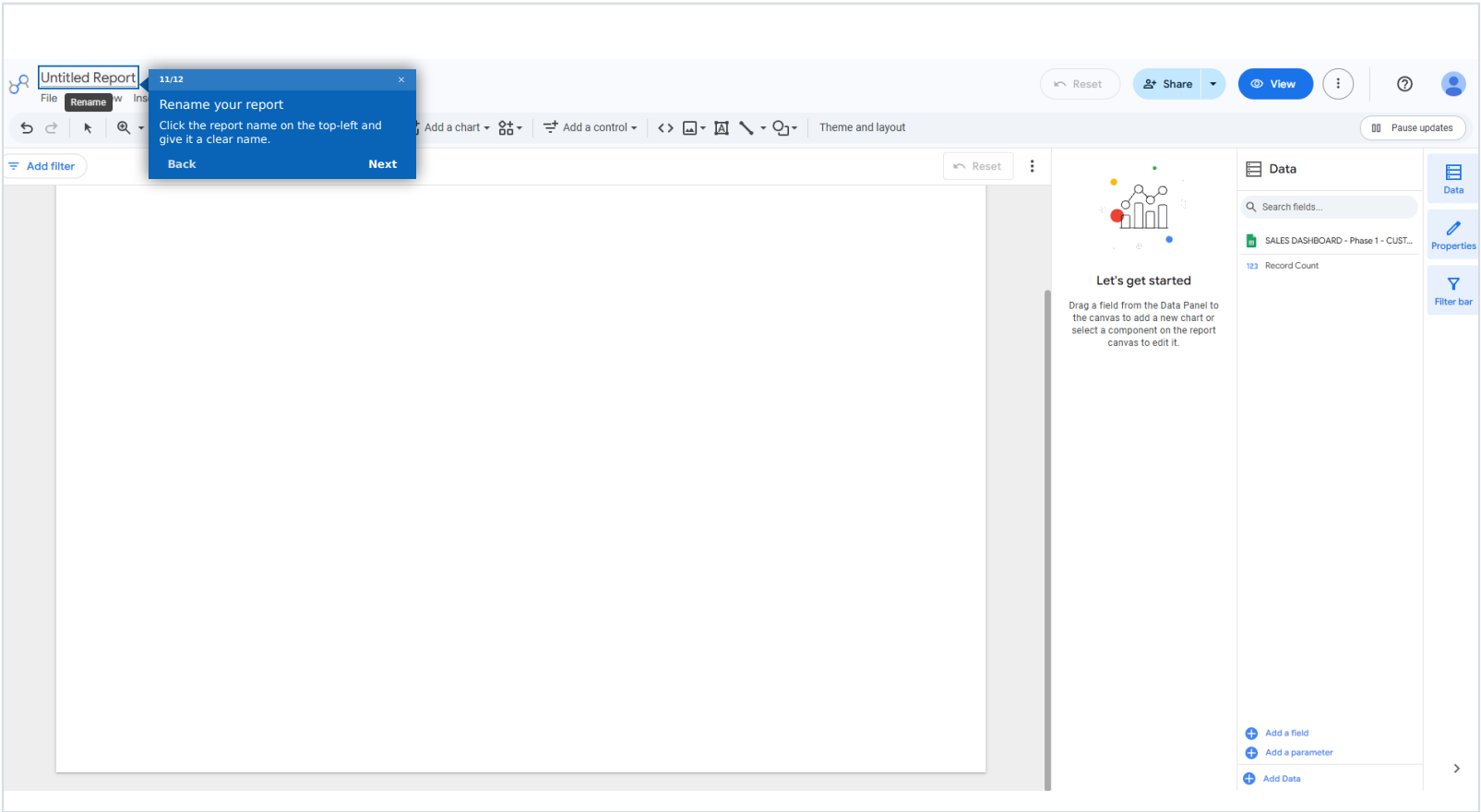
The data becomes a picture — the moment the tool starts to make sense.

ON-SCREEN COPY

“Click Add a chart and pick a chart type.”

STEP 11

Rename your report



WHY IT IS BUILT THIS WAY

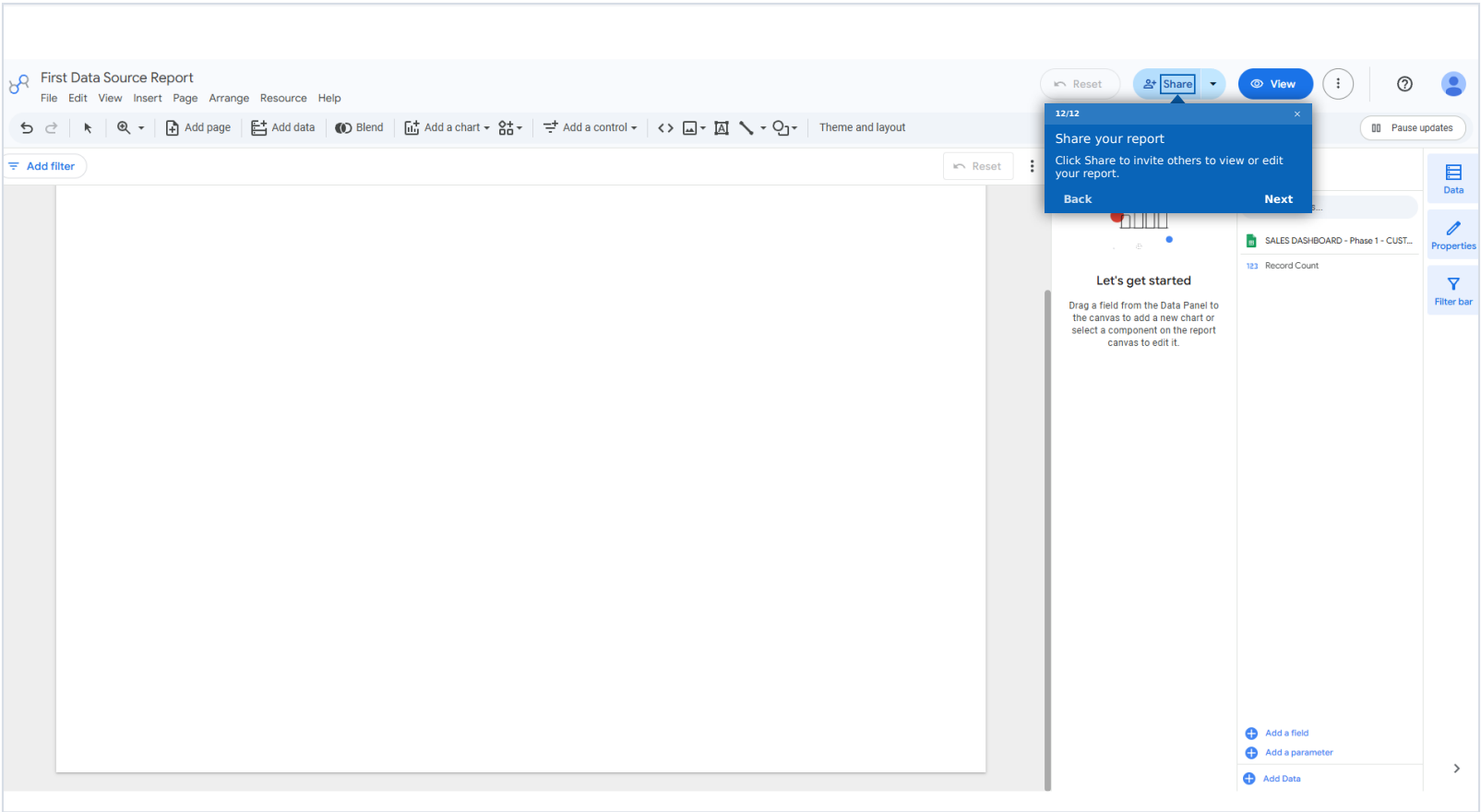
Small, but it is how the user finds this again tomorrow.

ON-SCREEN COPY

“Click the report name on the top-left and give it a clear name.”

STEP 12

Share your report



WHY IT IS BUILT THIS WAY

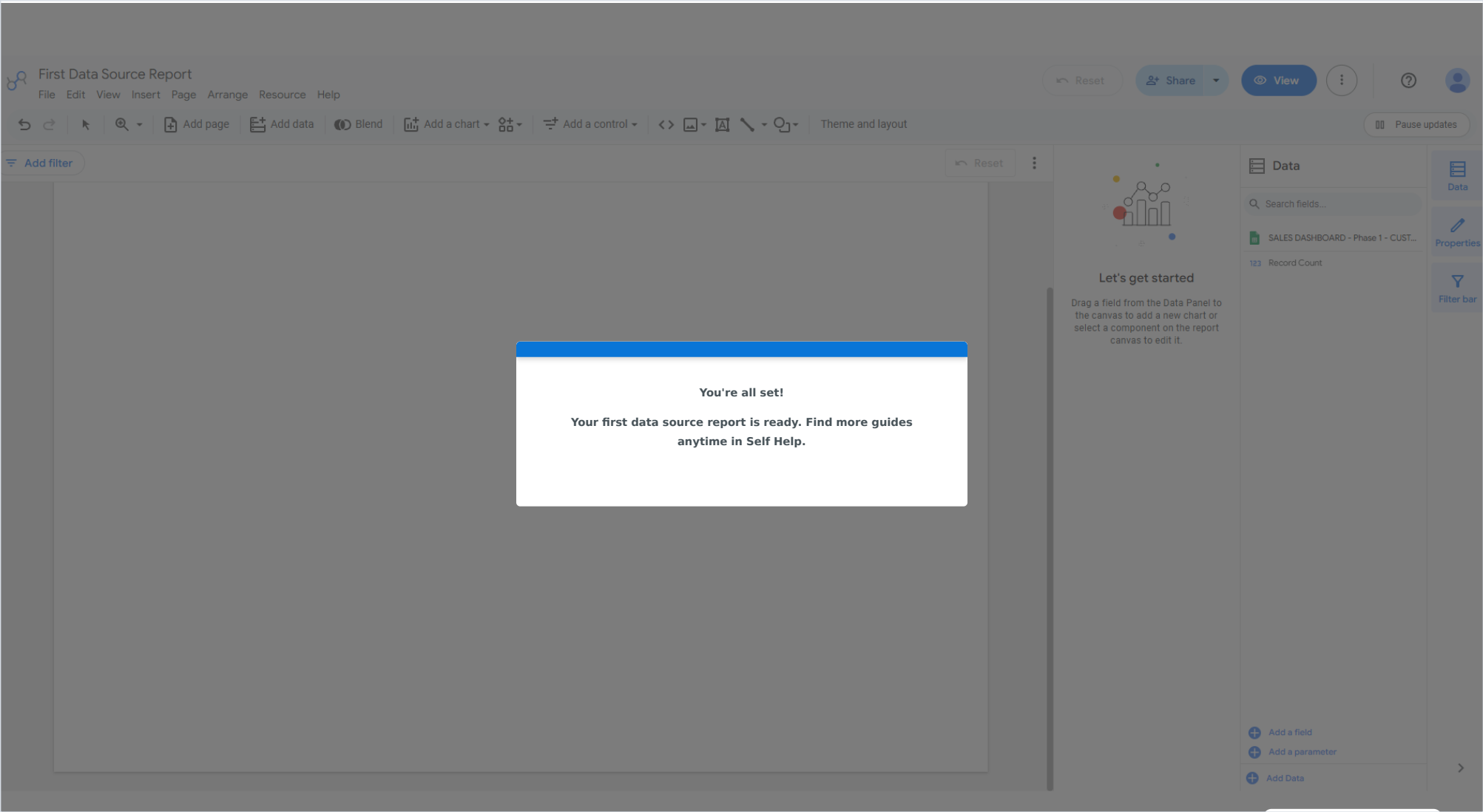
It ends on sharing rather than on "now explore": a report nobody sees is abandoned within the week.

ON-SCREEN COPY

“Click Share to invite others to view or edit your report.”

HANDOVER

Handover to Self Help



WHY IT IS BUILT THIS WAY

The final screen points at the Self Help panel. The walkthrough ends; the user's questions do not.

ON-SCREEN COPY

"Your first data source report is ready. Find more guides anytime in Self Help."

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Top 5 Flows for New Google Data Studio Users

The first journeys every beginner needs, why they matter, and how to do them.

Prepared by **Alisha Chaudhari**

01 Create your first report

Why it matters *This is the core “aha” moment. Users who build one report early are far more likely to return.*

1. Click **Create** → **Report**.
2. Pick a connector, select your data, click **Add** → **Add to report**.
3. Click **Untitled Report** to rename it. It saves automatically.

02 Connect and manage a data source

Why it matters *Every chart depends on it. Wrong field types or stale credentials cause most “my numbers look wrong” tickets.*

1. Click **Create** → **Data source**, then choose a connector (e.g. Google Sheets).
2. Select the file, click **Connect**.
3. Check each field’s data type and aggregation; click **Add a field** to create calculated fields.
4. Use **Refresh fields** when the source changes.

03 Start from a template

Why it matters *Beginners face a blank canvas. Templates show good design and cut setup time.*

1. Click **Templates** in the left menu.
2. Filter by category (e.g. Google Analytics, Sheets) and open one.
3. Click **Use my own data**, pick your data source, then click **Edit and share** to save it as your own report.

04 Add charts and interactive controls

Why it matters *Filters and date ranges turn a static page into a dashboard viewers can explore.*

1. In the editor, click **Add a chart** and choose a type; drag it onto the canvas.
2. In the **Setup** panel, set **Dimension** and **Metric**.
3. Click **Add a control** → **Date range control** or **Drop-down list**.
4. Click **View** to test it as a viewer.

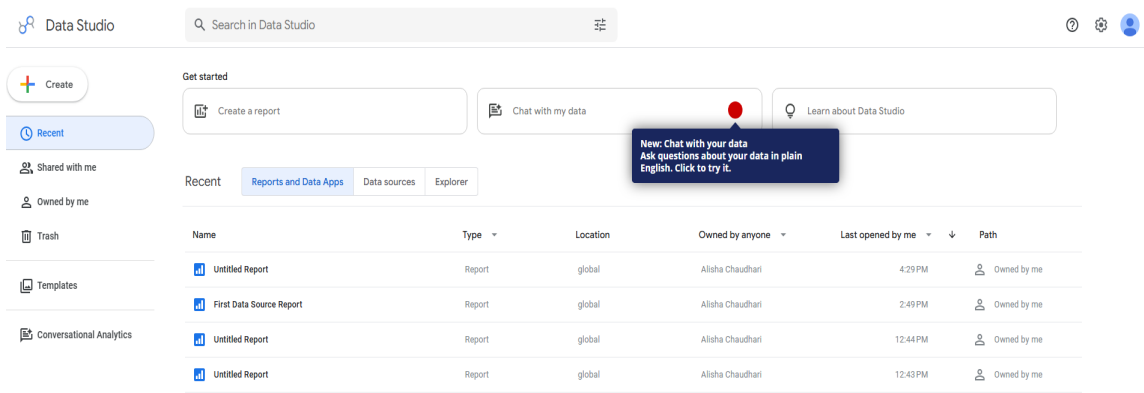
05 Share and schedule a report

Why it matters *Reports create value only when others see them. Scheduling keeps stakeholders updated without extra effort.*

1. Click **Share** → add people and choose **Can view** or **Can edit** → **Send**.
2. Or open the **Share** drop-down → **Get report link** → **Copy link**.
3. From the same drop-down, choose **Schedule delivery**, set recipients and frequency, then click **Schedule**.

Beacon

A pulsing hotspot that draws the eye to one element, without blocking the user.



Example: A beacon on the "Chat with my data" card tells users about this new feature on the Data Studio home page.

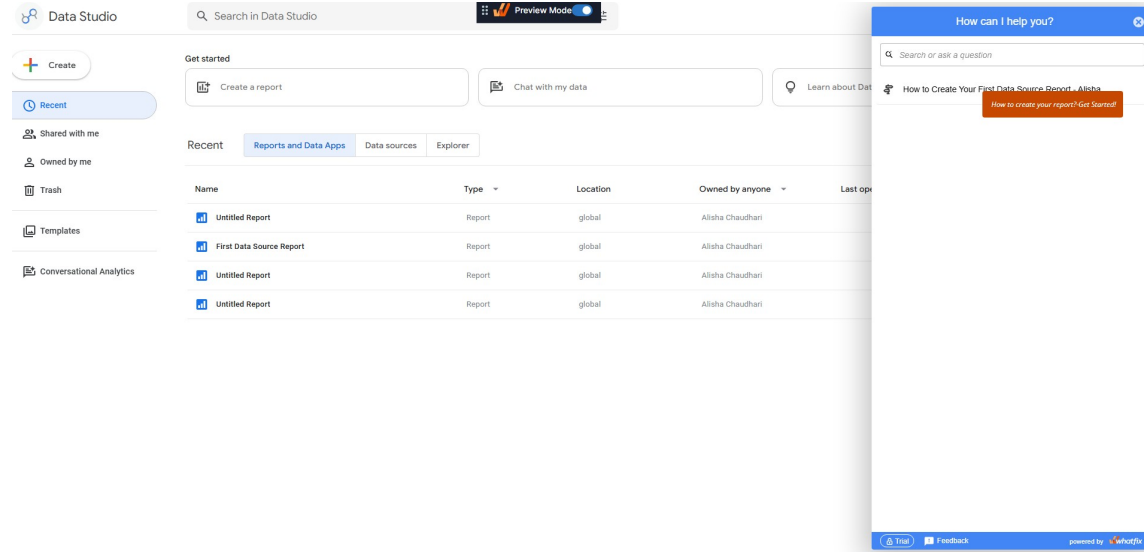
Use cases

- **Highlight a new feature:** point users to something new, like "Chat with my data".
- **Promote a useful feature:** remind users about tools they often miss, like Templates or Schedule delivery.
- **Show what changed:** mark a button or menu that moved or looks different after an update.
- **Offer more help:** let users click the beacon to start a step-by-step guide.

Set-up in Whatfix: Studio → Beacon → select "Chat with my data" → add tooltip text → set visibility (Data Studio domain; shows when the card is on screen; all users; up to 5 times) → Save.

Self Help

An in-app help widget: users search and launch guides, articles and videos without leaving Data Studio.



Example: The Self Help panel on the Data Studio home page lists the "How to Create Your First Data Source Report" walkthrough.

Use cases

- **Help at the moment of need:** users can ask questions like "How do I create a report?" without leaving Data Studio.
- **All help in one place:** walkthroughs, help articles and videos sit in a single panel.
- **Faster start, fewer tickets:** new users build their first report on their own, so they send fewer support requests.
- **Right help on the right page:** each page can show only the guides that fit it, like report guides inside the report editor.

Set-up in Whatfix: Dashboard → Widget → Create Widget → Self Help → add the walkthrough → set visibility (URL contains datastudio.google.com) → Save.

What I would measure

Guidance is only finished when there is a number attached to it. On a live account these are the four I would watch first.

Completion rate	How many users finish the walkthrough, and the exact step at which the rest stop.
Time to first report	How long a new user takes to produce something of their own.
Support volume	Questions about building a report, before and after publishing the guidance.
Empty help searches	Searches in Self Help that return nothing — the list of content still to write.

CLOSING

Building the guidance was the quick part. Deciding what to leave out took longer than recording the steps.

Software is not hard to buy. It is hard to get used.

Full write-up and files

github.com/ALISHA-19/gds-digital-adoption-case-study

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